

Picturing the Past

A visual record of the world's first non-violent freedom movement

By Dilip Bobb



THE ILLUSTRATED HISTORY OF THE FREEDOM STRUGGLE

Introduction by
PAVAN K. VARMA
Penguin Studio
Price: Rs 1,499
Pages: 143

The newest genre in literary circles is being called the South Block School of literature, a tongue-in-cheek reference to the number of serving diplomats who double as authors. Vikas Swarup (now called South Block Millionaire), Kiran Doshi, T.S. Tirumurti, Navtej Sarna, Nirupama Rao and, the most prolific of them all, Pavan K. Varma, who has just released his fourth literary endeavour, albeit one that is largely a collection of visual elements chronicling India's freedom struggle. As one of history's defining moments, the Freedom Movement, and its main protagonists, has been chronicled in such detail and by so many that it warrants a library of its own. A bibliography of over a hundred books and 60 some years later, the Freedom Well, one would assume, had run dry.

Varma, however, is made of sterner stuff. He has, wearing his author's hat, coupled history and research in compelling fashion in his earlier books. He is therefore, one of the few who could sift through history's debris and find a missing piece in the gigantic literary portrait the Independence Movement produced: a chronological illustrated account with some rare archival material. There have been books with photographs, history texts with maps and documents, but, surprisingly, none that combined photos, newspaper clippings, maps, documents and letters. It is, as Varma says, a selective iconography which attempts to explain why the movement captured

the imagination of the world. The long, often bloody struggle against colonialism and its British masters was one of history's most inspiring moments but more so because of the saga's hero, Mohandas 'Mahatma' Gandhi, and his unique strategy of non-violence and non-cooperation and the moral force he commanded. Not surprisingly then, he dominates the pictorial elements in this book.

Much of this is well-trodden history but Varma and the research team have put together a collection of iconography which is a visual record of the world's first non-violent movement that overthrew the most powerful empire the world has known. It is a record that stretches back to 1861 when Indians were first allowed to participate in the Governor General's Council. The researchers have trawled through existing archives in museums, libraries and newspaper

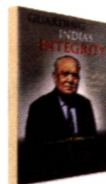
offices to compile this coffee table book which relives the collective sacrifice, idealism and the galaxy of leaders, giants compared to today's self-serving pygmies, who fought the most bloodless of wars.

Despite his lengthy and engrossing introduction and the rich pictorial tableau, one cannot escape the sense of déjà vu. In dealing with a period in history so

well documented, that was inevitable. Varma's literary endeavour is somewhat subliminal: he feels that Indians lack a sense of history and this is a timely reminder, in a time of widespread cynicism, that sacrifice and idealism can achieve great things. India, as an emerging global power, needs to be reminded of that, as does its predominantly young population. For a hard-nosed diplomat, that is idealism worth applauding. *Being Indian* was the title of his most critically acclaimed book, and this is a pictorial reminder of what exactly that definition means.



THE SECOND ROUND-TABLE CONFERENCE, ATTENDED BY MAHATMA GANDHI



GUARDING INDIA'S INTEGRITY: A PROACTIVE GOVERNOR SPEAKS

by LT GEN (RETD) S.K. SINHA

Manas
Price: Rs 595
Pages: 420

An autobiography of a governor who has headed two of India's most sensitive states: Assam and Jammu and Kashmir.

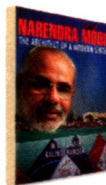


WHERE ARE YOU GOING, YOU MONKEYS?

by K.I. RAJANARAYANAN
Translated by PRITHAM K. CHAKRAVARTHY

Blaft Publications
Price: Rs 350
Pages: 235

A colourful and hilarious collection of folk tales from Tamil Nadu.



NARENDRA MODI: THE ARCHITECT OF A MODERN STATE

by M.V. KAMATH AND KALINDI RANDORI

Rupa
Price: Rs 395
Pages: 297

A biography of one of the most "mis-understood" chief ministers of India.